WHERE DOES THE UDDHAV SENA STAND?

STRENGTHS

- Shinde lacks organisational muscle beyond Thane and Palghar
- The split in the legislative wings has not translated on the ground among the cadre/ voters, who are seen as loyal to the Thackerays
- Politics in Mumbai is getting increasingly polarised on linguistic and cultural lines; Marathi voters may coalesce around Sena (UBT)
- A united MVA is a potent challenger to the BJP and Shinde

WEAKNESSES

- Shiv Sena's vote base has stopped growing
- Marathi speakers on the decline in Mumbai. Changed demographic favour national parties like the BJP
- Uddhav Thackeray's perceived inaccessibility
- Lack of opportunities to rise in party makes middle-rung leaders easy pickings for Shinde, BJP

OPPORTUNITIES

- The party has undergone a debilitating split but it can now risk new social and political experiments to cultivate a new vote base
- Can fill up much of anti-incumbency space in parts of the state
- Potential for a cultural mobilisation through a ground-up and non-Brahmin version of Hindutva to counter the BJP

THREATS

- Control over the Mumbai civic body helped the Shiv Sena foster a 'reward economy' for its party machinery. BMC's term ended in Nov. 2022, and there is no sign of elections; it may lead to a drift
- The UBT Sena has been unable to respond to the caste churn in Maharashtra after the Marathas began their protest for reservations. This agitation has sharpened the OBC versus Maratha divide
- Emergence of a cosmopolitan Maharashtrian voter who prefers the BJP
- Old tactics like linguistic chauvinism, anti-migrant politics are out of season. Lack of an ideology or an economic blueprint

voted for him twice. Modi is about muscular politics, nationalism and infrastructure.... Sena (UBT), on the other hand, has watered down its position to play a civic variety of politics, with little connect to its core voters," he says. "They will soon realise they have paid a heavy price for compromising their ideology."

There is also a feeling, both in the BJP and Shinde camps, that the Shiv Sena's vote base has stopped growing due to a decline in its core Maharashtrian vote base. The gentrification of traditional Marathi neighbourhoods and the resultant influx of elite non-Maharashtrian groups in these areas has changed the demographic and political profile. "Majoritarian assertion will set the tune in the poll narrative. Political controversies do not necessarily lead to electoral dividends," says a source from the Shinde faction.

UDDHAV ALSO HAS TO REMIND HIS MARATHI CORE BASE THAT THE SENA WAS IN THE FOREFRONT OF THE RAM MANDIR AGITATION; THAT BALASAHEB WAS THE ORIGINAL 'HINDU HRIDAY SAMRAT'

THE ROAD AHEAD

Thackeray will have to strike a delicate balance—while cultivating new voters, he'll also have to keep reminding his Marathi core base that the Sena had led from the front in the Ram Mandir agitation; that the late Bal Thackeray was the original 'Hindu hriday samrat'. Thackeray may also have to re-brand his party as a pan-Maharashtra regional outfit to go beyond identity politics and address issues like the state getting a raw deal from the Union government despite being the economic engine of the country. This may help it become a regional force like the parties down South.

A senior Congress leader says politics in the post-Ram mandir, post-Mandal era is governed more by emotion than by tangible gains and governance. Sympathy for the 'wronged' Sena and MVA will be a primary plank, but the narrative that the BJP is misusing central enforcement agencies to split Opposition parties is also likely to strike a chord with voters. "But the Thackerays must launch an outreach programme to capture the sentiment in favour of our alliance," he says.

Political analyst Abhay Deshpande says Thackeray will have to play the victim card. "The Thackerays and the Shiv Sena can't be delinked. That may be their strategy in the future," he says. He also feels that despite everything, the MVA still has a good chance in Maharashtra. "The BJP will fight the polls as a referendum on Modi. Even then, the MVA has an edge as the split in the legislative and parliamentary wings of the Shiv Sena and the NCP has not translated into a similar split of their cadre and voters on the ground," he explains.

The MVA could also focus on issues that stoke regional sentiments—like the flight of investment projects to Gujarat. "But Thackeray will face a dilemma on the Hindutva issue. While trying to get Dalit and Muslim votes on an anti-BJP plank, he will also have to tom-tom his pro-Hindutva links to keep his core base," warns Deshpande. Managing this contradiction is the only way Uddhav's Sena can stay relevant in Maharashtra. ■